appellations, gave serious thought to just calling Valentine's Day *Kamadeva Divas*, to link it to ancient Hindu culture?

But it's in the 'self-appointed' part that the real problem lies. All this is being done in the name of a notion of Indian culture whose assertion is based on a denial of India's real rather than imagined past. India's culture has always been a capacious one, expanding to include new and varied influences, from the Greek invasions to the British. The central battle in contemporary Indian civilisation is that between those who, to borrow from Walt Whitman, acknowledge that as a result of our own historical experience, we are vast, we contain multitudes, and those who have presumptuously taken it upon themselves to define—in increasingly narrower terms—what is 'truly' Indian.

TARNISHING THE TAJ

The latest victim of this definitional exercise is India's most iconic monument, the Taj Mahal. In a country whose toxic politics has led to everything—from festival firecrackers to animal husbandry (the care and protection of cows, of which more anon)—taking on a 'communal', religious colouring, it shouldn't be too much of a surprise that its most famous monument hasn't been exempt.

The Taj Mahal is India's most magnificent piece of architecture. Built nearly four centuries ago by the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan as a mausoleum for his beloved wife, who had borne him thirteen children and died in the process of producing the fourteenth, it attracts tens of millions of tourists and is by far the country's most-photographed building. The exquisite marble monument to love was hailed by India's only winner of the Nobel Prize for literature, Rabindranath Tagore, as 'a teardrop on the cheek of Time'.

But the Taj now has other reasons for tears. Its gleaming white surface is yellowing as a result of rampant air pollution from factories and small businesses around it, as well as the Mathura refinery not far way. Repairs are needed so frequently that scaffolding often obscures its famous minarets. There has been a 35 per cent drop in foreign tourists from the 743,000 who went there in 2012 to the 480,000 tourists who came in 2015.[22] The crowded and grimy town of Agra in Uttar Pradesh, which